

Classification of Target Population Categories

Overview: We classified surgical study populations according to demographic and clinical groupings commonly used in surgical research, including general adult patients, pediatric cohorts, elderly populations, and explicitly defined high-risk groups.

Category 1 — General Surgical Population

Definition: Default category for adult surgical patients when no specific demographic criteria are provided. Applies to studies that describe their cohort simply as “adult surgical patients.”

Category 2 — Pediatric Population

Definition: Patients explicitly identified as pediatric, including children, infants, neonates, or adolescents (typically ≤ 18 years).

Category 3 — Older Adults / Elderly Population

Definition: Patients characterized as elderly, older adults, or geriatric, or defined using an age threshold consistent with geriatric criteria (e.g., ≥ 65 years).

Category 4 — High-Risk Patients

Definition: Patients designated as high risk due to critical illness, ICU admission, mechanical ventilation, or explicit labeling by the study as “high-risk surgical patients.”